

Claire Finley

Curriculum Vitae

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Education

Ph.D. Astrophysics, University of California, Santa Barbara	May 2026 – Present
Advisor: Dr. Brendan P. Bowler	
M.A. Astronomy, The University of Texas at Austin	December 2025
Thesis: <i>Tracing Accretion and Variability in the Young Giant Planet SR 12 c</i>	
Advisor: Dr. Brendan P. Bowler	
B.S. Astronomy and Astrophysics, Villanova University	May 2023
<i>Cum Laude, minors in Physics and Art History</i>	

Appointments

University of California, Santa Barbara	May 2026 – Present
Graduate Student Researcher	<i>Goleta, CA</i>
The University of Texas at Austin	August 2023 – May 2026
Graduate Research Assistant	<i>Austin, TX</i>
NASA Goddard Space Flight Center	June 2022 – August 2022
OSTEM Summer Intern	<i>Greenbelt, MD</i>
Green Bank Observatory & National Radio Astronomy Observatory	June 2021 – August 2021
Research Experience for Undergraduates (REU)	<i>Green Bank, WV</i>
Villanova University	January 2021 – May 2023
Teaching Assistant	January 2020 - May 2021
Undergraduate Research Assistant	August 2019 - March 2020
Public Observatory Attendant	<i>Villanova, PA</i>
Adler Planetarium	June 2018 – August 2018
Citizen Science and Space Visualization Intern	<i>Chicago, IL</i>

Research Interests

- Formation and evolution of giant planets using direct imaging
- Planetary accretion processes and circumplanetary disk properties

Awards and Honors

Jason A. Cardelli Memorial Award for Undergraduate Research	April 2023
Sigma Pi Sigma Physics Honor Society	February 2023
John Mather Nobel Scholarship	July 2022
Certificate of Achievement in Ethical Leadership	November 2020

Contributed Publications

1. *Ultraviolet Imaging of SR 12 c with HST/WFC3: Accretion and Variability of a Giant Planet at the End Stages of Growth*
Claire O. Finley, Brendan P. Bowler, Ya-Lin Wu, Adam L. Kraus, Yifan Zhou et al.
2026 eprint arXiv:2606.12862 (accepted to AJ)
1. *Modeling the “Dark-matter Dominated” Dwarf Galaxy Segue 1 with a Supermassive Black Hole*
Nathaniel Lujan, Karl Gebhardt, Richard Anantua, Owen Chase, Maya H. Debski, **Claire Finley** et al.
2025 ApJL 992 L25

Scientific Presentations

Contributed talks

Exoplanets 6

June 2026

Porto, Portugal

Spirit of Lyot 6

February 2026

CalTech, Pasadena, CA

51 Pegasi b: Cool Giant Planets and Their Systems

October 2025

Observatoire de Haute Provence, France

Division for Planetary Sciences Meeting #54

October 2023

London, Ontario

Contributed posters

2025 Sagan Summer Workshop Silver Jubilee: Exoplanet Demographics

July 2025

Pasadena, California

American Astronomical Society Meeting #240

June 2022

Pasadena, California

Observing Proposals

As Co-Investigator

HST Cycle 33 GO 18139, PI Jiang: “Tracing Accretion in the Planetary Regime: A Comprehensive UV/Optical Survey of the Late Stages of Planet Formation”, 60 orbits awarded

JWST Cycle 4 GO 7538, PI Cugno: “Giants in the making: the composition of circumplanetary disks with JWST MIRI-MRS”, 59.2 hours awarded

JWST Cycle 4 GO 9091, PI Morgan: “Imaging a Hidden Super-Jupiter Accelerating its Metal-rich M-dwarf Host”, 16.1 hours awarded

Leadership and Mentorship

The University of Texas at Austin

August 2023 – May 2026

Graduate mentor: Graduate-Undergraduate Mentorship in astronoMY program

Villanova University

President: Villanova Astronomical Society

April 2022 - May 2023

Treasurer: Villanova Astronomical Society

April 2021 - April 2022

Student mentor: Astrophysics Mentorship Program

August 2020 - May 2023

Outreach

Astronomy on Tap ATX

September 2024 - May

Host and member of leadership team

2026

Computational Proficiency and Instrument Experience

Languages: Python, IDL, S-Lang, SigmaPlot, Swift

Observing experience: NIRSPEC, OSIRIS, and NIRC2 at W.M. Keck Observatory; NASA’s IRTF iSHELL; 30-inch telescope at McDonald Observatory